Taranaki Secondary Schools Rogaining Championships 2014
Nick Collins

After a very successful event in 2013, we started talking about capping numbers. How many after all is too many. Having failed to find an equitable way of doing this, we drifted into 2014s organization having failed to make a decision. Imagine our surprise when we found we had **954** students pre-entered.

Some aspects of the event organization inevitably resembled an organized shambles. The sound system for example proved to be inadequate in the strong winds and so the briefing was a complete failure. This was compounded by the start, when 30 marshals formed a cordon containing the 954 impatient students while I counted down. Unfortunately none of the marshals could hear me and their futile attempts to contain the stampede were extremely entertaining from my safe vantage point.

Many aspects of the event had been tweaked to improve some of the problems we have had in previous years. A protest desk in line between Navlight download and sausages for example allowed students to sort out any perceived problems. A rented light tower allowed us to have better control of the event site and reduced problems with rubbish. A redesigned finish chute kept spectators from blocking the finish area.

Once again the very professional Taranaki Search and Rescue team played a vital role in the event. We had 5 or so minor injuries where the students required "rescuing" mainly for sprained ankles. SAR were kept busy collecting these people and bringing them in for St Johns to deal with.

Sadly we do not have photos this year. Our photographer Pete Wood had a heart attack several days before the event while climbing Mt. Taranaki (Egmont) by himself. He managed to get back to his car and then despite having one arm not working drove himself to hospital. Pete has made a full recovery and will hopefully ensure we have photos next year.

The trouble with events like this is its all very "Ground Hog" day. Here we go again, lets get organized; changes to stress over what we have forgotten and why the event will be a disaster; elation as the event finishes; fatigue as you tidy up; promise to yourself that this is the last time and then the horrible realization that you are already thinking about the improvements you will make. Maybe we should put a cap on the numbers in 2015.

My thanks go to the huge team of volunteers without whom this event would be implausible.

Nick Collins
2nd April 2014